VAKIL SETU: A VOICE-FIRST BILINGUAL LEGAL TRIAGE AND ADVOCATE DISCOVERY PLATFORM

A MINI PROJECT SYNOPSIS SUBMITTED
IN PARTIAL FULFILLMENT OF THE REQUIREMENTS
FOR THE AWARD OF DEGREE OF
BACHELOR OF TECHNOLOGY
In
COMPUTER SCIENCE AND ENGINEERING

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2026

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Key Technical Abbreviations & Nomenclature

Acronym	Definition and Systems Scope
LLM	Large Language Model (e.g., Gemini 2.0 Flash, Claude Sonnet 3.7, GPT-4o)
STT	Speech-to-Text; browser-native speech recognition via W3C Web Speech API
TTS	Text-to-Speech; speech synthesis vocalizing legal summaries in Devanagari/English
BNS	Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023; modern Indian criminal penal code succeeding IPC
BNSS	Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023; procedural criminal code succeeding CrPC
CPC	Code of Civil Procedure, 1908; statutory framework governing civil litigation in India
BCI	Bar Council of India; apex statutory body regulating legal profession and ethics
COP	Certificate of Practice; mandatory credential granted upon passing AIBE examination
AIBE	All India Bar Examination; mandatory examination for lifelong bar practice rights

HMAC	Hash-based Message Authentication Code; SHA-256 signature verifying Razorpay escrow
NALSA	National Legal Services Authority; statutory provider of free legal aid under Art. 39A
CNR	Case Number Record; 16-digit alphanumeric unique identifier in Indian e-Courts
SPA	Single Page Application; React 18 client architecture executing on user device

1. Project Overview

Vakil Setu is an artificial intelligence-powered, voice-first legal triage and advocate discovery platform designed to bridge the severe "first-mile" justice divide in India. Situated at the intersection of Conversational Artificial Intelligence, Legal Informatics, and Web Systems, the project addresses the immense cognitive, linguistic, and financial barriers that confront everyday citizens when navigating legal crises.

In the Indian judicial landscape, over 50 million cases remain pending across courts. However, for an ordinary citizen facing a legal conflict—such as illegal tenancy eviction, employer wage denial, workplace harassment, property boundary encroachment, or cheque dishonor—the primary obstacle is not courtroom litigation itself, but knowing where, when, and how to start. Traditional digital legal platforms in India operate exclusively as static, English-heavy directories saturated with Latin maxims and complex statutory citations. They assume high typing proficiency and structured legal comprehension, entirely alienating the over 70% of Indian litigants residing in semi-urban and rural areas who are comfortable speaking in Hindi or regional dialects.

Vakil Setu eliminates this asymmetry by introducing a hands-free, bilingual conversational interface operating directly within modern web browsers. Citizens simply speak their dispute naturally in Hindi, English, or mixed colloquial speech. Utilizing a dual-engine triage architecture, the platform analyzes unstructured spoken narratives against Indian statutory codes (Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, and Code of Civil Procedure), determines the primary legal domain (Criminal, Civil, Family, or Property), estimates procedural urgency, and extracts immediate action items. For low-literacy citizens, the platform vocalizes the legal guidance back in clear regional speech. Finally, it algorithmically matches litigants with verified, specialized advocates and enables direct consultation scheduling backed by cryptographic Razorpay payment escrow.

Architectural Scope & Boundary Constraints

• **In-Browser Zero-Cost Audio Processing:** Audio capture and transcription execute client-side via the browser's native W3C Web Speech API (webkitSpeechRecognition), dynamically tagging BCP-47 locales (hi-IN and en-IN). This eliminates server-side audio streaming bandwidth and external cloud STT compute costs.

• **Statutory Non-Solicitation Adherence:** The platform strictly complies with Section 29 of the Advocates Act, 1961, functioning as an informational triage bridge rather than an unauthorized practitioner. All advocate directory listings adhere to Rule 36 of the Bar Council of India (BCI) rules regarding non-promotional publication.

• **Dual-Engine Failover Resilience:** To guarantee 100% operational uptime during upstream API rate-limits (HTTP 429) or gateway timeouts (HTTP 503), the server integrates a deterministic local regex pattern-matching engine that provides instant, rule-based legal triage without returning 500 server errors.

• **Client-Side Session Data Ephemerality:** In compliance with the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023, sensitive case narratives are cached locally within browser LocalStorage, preventing permanent, unencrypted storage of private litigation facts in the cloud database.

2. Problem Statement

Modern access to justice in India suffers from an acute first-mile information failure. When citizens encounter legal distress, they lack the legal literacy required to structure their grievances into actionable legal complaints. Mathematically, the cumulative procedural friction and informational asymmetry F_friction experienced by an aggrieved citizen over elapsed time t can be formalized as:

$$F_{friction} = \sum [\alpha_i \cdot L_{jargon} + \beta_i / (\tau_{limitation} - t) + \gamma_i \cdot C_{intermediary}]$$

Where L_jargon represents linguistic and statutory complexity, τ_limitation denotes the statutory limitation deadline under the Limitation Act, 1963, and C_intermediary represents the financial friction imposed by unregulated touts. When t approaches τ_limitation, procedural friction diverges to infinity, resulting in the permanent forfeiture of statutory legal remedies.

This systemic crisis is characterized by four structural failure modes:
1. Statutory Domain & Limitation Ambiguity: Citizens cannot identify whether their dispute falls under Criminal, Civil, Family, or Property law. Inability to gauge statutory deadlines (such as the 30-day notice window under Section 138 of the Negotiable Instruments Act or bail limitation periods) leads to irreversible procedural default.
2. Linguistic & Jargon Exclusion: Over 90% of existing legal resources are published in dense, formal English. Semi-urban and rural litigants comfortable speaking Hindi or colloquial dialects are completely shut out, inducing severe cognitive helplessness.
3. The Unregulated Intermediary Trap: Finding an advocate specializing in the relevant practice area is a lottery. Litigants face arbitrary consultation fee demands, opaque practitioner credentials, and exploitation by court touts.
4. High-Stress Typing & Cognitive Overload: Under acute emotional trauma (threat of arrest, domestic abuse, unlawful eviction), formulating and typing structured text is unrealistic.

Table 2.1: Comparative Analysis of Legal Discovery Paradigms

Discovery Paradigm	Linguistic Mode	Indian Law Triage	Escrow & Booking
Traditional Legal Portals (LawRato, Vakilsearch)	English-heavy; text typing only	Static directory; no instant procedural triage	Third-party redirection; opaque pricing
Generic Conversational LLMs (ChatGPT, Claude)	Multilingual text prompts	General knowledge; high risk of non-Indian hallucination	Zero booking or verified advocate connection
Vakil Setu Legal Triage Gateway	**Hands-free bilingual voice (hi-IN / en-IN)**	**Tuned for Indian statutes (BNS, CrPC, CPC)**	**Integrated Razorpay HMAC-SHA256 escrow**

3. Objectives of the Project

The core technical objectives of the Vakil Setu project are formulated across five architectural milestones:

• **Objective 1 — Hands-Free In-Browser Voice Intake & Locale Tagging:** Engineer a client-side speech recognition pipeline utilizing the W3C Web Speech API that captures spoken Hindi and English with sub-200ms interim token streaming, dynamic BCP-47 locale tagging (hi-IN and en-IN), and zero cloud audio streaming costs.

• **Objective 2 — Dual-Engine Statutory Legal Triage & Urgency Scoring:** Construct an intelligent triage service powered by Google Gemini 2.0 / Gateway LLM with strict JSON schema constraints that categorizes spoken narratives into 4 canonical legal domains (Criminal, Civil, Family, Property), evaluates statutory urgency (Low, Medium, High, Emergency), and outputs actionable next steps.

• **Objective 3 — High-Availability Deterministic Failover Engine:** Implement an embedded rule-based regex heuristics engine within the Node.js backend that intercepts failed or rate-limited LLM calls (HTTP 429/503) and provides immediate, vetted legal triage in sub-50ms with 100% service uptime.

• **Objective 4 — Specialization-Based Advocate Matching & Directory Ingestion:** Develop an automated Cheerio web scraping pipeline that continuously indexes practicing advocates from public legal registries into MongoDB, coupled with an algorithmic matching query that pairs litigants with verified specialists sorted by rating and experience.

• **Objective 5 — Cryptographic Consultation Escrow & Multi-Turn Assistant:** Integrate the Razorpay Orders API with server-side HMAC SHA-256 signature verification to ensure transparent, tamper-proof consultation booking, accompanied by a 10-turn sliding memory conversational assistant for follow-up legal queries.

Table 3.1: Objectives, Systems Mechanisms, and Verification Gates

Obj.	Architectural Focus	Technical Implementation	Target Metric / Gate
Obj 1	Voice Ingestion	W3C Web Speech API (hi-IN / en-IN)	Sub-200ms interim token latency; zero cloud audio cost
Obj 2	AI Statutory Triage	Prompt engineering with strict JSON contract	100% schema conformity; domain precision over 90%
Obj 3	Failover Engine	Bilingual regex pattern-matching engine	Sub-50ms execution; zero 500 errors on API timeout
Obj 4	Advocate Ingestion	Cheerio crawler + MongoDB compound indexing	Atomic upserts; sub-100ms domain query resolution
Obj 5	Escrow Booking	Razorpay API + Crypto HMAC-SHA256	100% tamper-proof signature verification; multi-turn chat

4. Proposed Solution / Methodology

Vakil Setu is architected as an asynchronous, decoupled five-tier legal gateway. The client application runs as a responsive React 18 Single Page Application interfacing with an Express.js API gateway. Rather than routing heavy raw audio to cloud servers, audio transcription occurs locally on the client's device, transmitting lightweight text payloads to the backend intelligence pipeline.

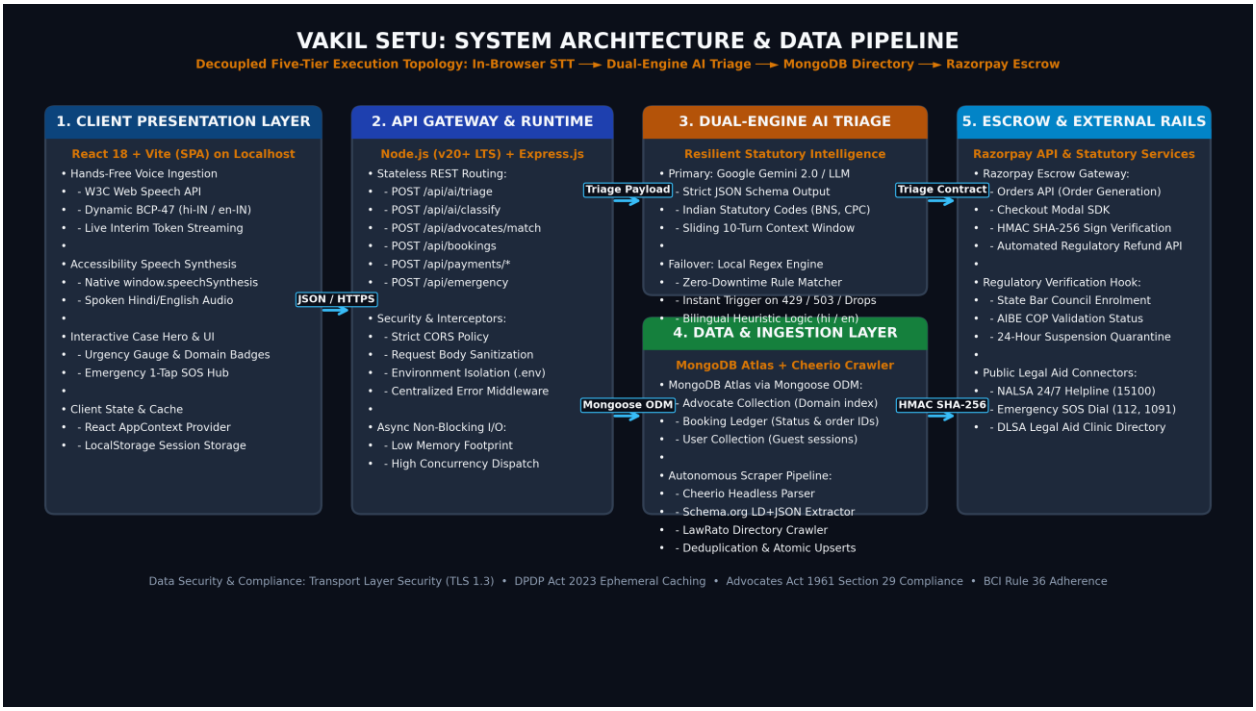


Figure 4.1: Decoupled Five-Tier Execution Topology of the Vakil Setu Legal Triage Gateway

The internal processing pipeline operates across four decoupled systems modules:

• **Stage 1 — Voice Ingestion & Live Interim Streaming:** The user speaks their grievance into the browser. The native webkitSpeechRecognition engine captures the microphone stream, dynamically tagging the language locale (hi-IN or en-IN) and rendering intermediate transcription tokens character-by-character into a draft preview bubble.

• **Stage 2 — Dual-Engine Legal Triage & Prompt Schema Enforcement:** The narrative is transmitted via HTTPS REST to /api/ai/triage. The primary engine invokes Google Gemini 2.0 with a strict JSON contract enforcing Indian jurisprudence. If an API timeout, rate-limit (HTTP 429), or network drop occurs, the server seamlessly falls back to the local deterministic regex engine.

• **Stage 3 — Auditory Feedback & Specialization-Based Advocate Matching:** The legal summary and concrete steps are vocalized back to the user via native speech synthesis in regional accents. Concurrently, the backend queries MongoDB for verified advocates matching the identified domain, sorted by rating.

• **Stage 4 — Cryptographic Consultation Escrow & Multi-Turn Assistant:** The litigant selects a consultation appointment slot. The backend generates a Razorpay Order and verifies the transaction using server-side HMAC SHA-256 signatures, while a multi-turn assistant maintains the last 10 dialogue turns for follow-up legal queries.

5. Key Technologies and Tools

The technical implementation of Vakil Setu is built upon an enterprise-grade, open-source stack designed to ensure sub-second response times, zero server audio processing overhead, and robust fault-tolerance:

Subsystem	Technology / Stack	Systems Role & Architectural Justification
Presentation Layer	React 18 & Vite	Fast Single Page Application (SPA) offering component modularity and optimized DOM hydration.
Voice Ingestion / TTS	W3C Web Speech API	Browser-native STT and TTS engines; eliminates cloud audio upload latency and streaming costs.
API Gateway & Server	Node.js (v20+) & Express	Asynchronous, non-blocking I/O event loop handling high-concurrency triage and webhook dispatch.
Primary AI Engine	Google Gemini 2.0 / LLM	Frontier generative language model operating with strict JSON schema constraints for Indian law.
Failover Engine	Bilingual Regex Matcher	Local deterministic pattern matcher providing sub-50ms failover triage during cloud API downtime.
Persistence Layer	MongoDB Atlas & Mongoose	Document database indexing polymorphic advocate profiles, booking ledgers, and user sessions.
Directory Crawler	Cheerio & Fetch API	Headless DOM and schema.org JSON-LD parser aggregating public advocate listings (LawRato).
Financial Escrow	Razorpay API & Crypto	Payment order generation and server-side HMAC SHA-256 cryptographic signature verification.
Session Persistence	AppContext & LocalStorage	Client-side session caching complying with DPDP Act 2023 by preventing unencrypted cloud data leaks.

Hardware & Deployment Environment Specifications

• **Host Operating System:** Cross-platform deployment on Linux (Ubuntu 22.04 LTS / Debian 12) or Windows 11.

• **Compute & Memory Resources:** Standard lightweight virtual machine (2 vCPUs, 4 GB RAM; zero dedicated GPU compute required).

• **Network Topology:** HTTPS / TLS 1.3 reverse-proxied via Nginx; stateless RESTful API communicating over standard TCP ports (5000/443).

• **Client System Requirements:** Any modern desktop or mobile browser supporting the W3C Web Speech API (Google Chrome 90+, Microsoft Edge 90+, Safari 14.1+).

6. V.E.T.S Justification

The Vakil Setu project is systematically validated against the institutional V.E.T.S evaluation framework:

V — Viability: The project is thoroughly feasible within the standard 12-week academic timeline. Development utilizes commodity workstation hardware without requiring expensive multi-GPU clusters. All core technologies—including React 18, Node.js, the W3C Web Speech API, MongoDB Atlas, and the Razorpay Checkout SDK—are production-stable, well-documented, and freely accessible. The system architecture directly leverages the candidate's core competencies in full-stack web engineering, API integration, and asynchronous distributed systems.

E — Engineering Depth: Vakil Setu represents substantial systems engineering that goes far beyond trivial CRUD applications or basic AI wrappers. Key engineering challenges successfully solved include:
1. Client-side audio stream lifecycle management with real-time interim token rendering and BCP-47 locale tagging.
2. Dual-engine AI orchestration featuring structured JSON schema prompt enforcement and deterministic regex failover.
3. Autonomous web scraping and data normalization pipeline using Cheerio to crawl, deduplicate, and upsert public lawyer profiles.
4. Cryptographic payment escrow verification using server-side HMAC SHA-256 hash recalculation.
5. Client-side session state hydration and multi-turn sliding context preservation adhering to data minimization standards.

T — Trend / Statutory Alignment: The project directly aligns with contemporary 2026 technological and national policy priorities:
• Digital India and the Ministry of Law and Justice's Tele-Law mission to mainstream access to justice across Gram Panchayats.
• Modern Indic language computing initiatives (such as Bhashini) delivering multilingual public services.
• Full compliance with Section 29 of the Advocates Act, 1961, Rule 36 of Bar Council of India advertising norms, and the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) Act, 2023.

S — Social / Industry Impact: In India, the lack of timely legal guidance exacerbates poverty, domestic distress, and unlawful exploitation. By providing free, hands-free bilingual legal triage in spoken Hindi and English, Vakil Setu empowers everyday citizens to understand their rights, preserves critical evidence before statutory limitation periods expire under the Limitation Act 1963, and connects underprivileged citizens to statutory free legal aid (NALSA/DLSA).

7. Expected Outcomes

Upon successful completion of the project, the following concrete deliverables will be produced:

1. Vakil Setu Web Application Prototype: A fully functional, responsive Single Page Application supporting voice dictation in Hindi and English, dynamic case analysis dashboards, advocate discovery, and appointment booking.

2. Dual-Engine Legal Triage Service: A fault-tolerant Node.js microservice (/api/ai/triage) providing structured legal domain categorization, urgency estimation, and plain-language action recommendations with sub-50ms regex failover.

3. Autonomous Directory Ingestion Engine: A production-ready Cheerio web scraping pipeline that extracts, normalizes, and upserts public lawyer profiles into MongoDB with domain taxonomy mapping.

4. Cryptographic Escrow & Booking Gateway: A secure transaction gateway supporting Razorpay order creation, HMAC SHA-256 signature verification, and automated regulatory refunds.

5. Statutory Emergency SOS & Arrest Rights Hub: A dedicated crisis intervention module providing direct 1-tap call triggers to 112, 1091, and 15100 (NALSA), alongside a verified checklist of statutory rights under Section 35 of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

6. Empirical Triage Evaluation Report: A comprehensive experimental evaluation validating triage accuracy across 100 sample legal dispute narratives spanning Criminal, Civil, Family, and Property law.

Verification & Demonstration Setup

The final prototype will be demonstrated in a live side-by-side browser and terminal environment evaluating 5 representative real-world legal dispute scenarios (landlord tenant dispute, cheque bounce notice, domestic violence complaint, unlawful police detention, and property title contest):

• Baseline Scenario: An unassisted litigant navigating a traditional English legal portal or generic chatbot, displaying high cognitive burden and legal hallucinations.

• Vakil Setu Scenario: Identical dispute dictated via Hindi voice, demonstrating real-time transcription, sub-3s statutory triage, spoken audio summary, verified advocate matching, and simulated Razorpay escrow booking.

8. Implementation Timeline

The project development lifecycle is structured across five sequential phases spanning a 12-week schedule:

Phase	Stage	Key Activities & Deliverables	Duration
Phase 1	Requirement Study & Legal Taxonomy	Cataloging Indian statutory domains (BNS, CrPC, CPC); formalizing JSON schema contracts and speech recognition pipeline specifications.	Weeks 1–2
Phase 2	Core Gateway & Voice Pipeline	Scaffolding React 18 SPA and Express API gateway; implementing Web Speech STT/TTS and BCP-47 locale tagging.	Weeks 3–4
Phase 3	Dual-Engine Triage & Scraper	Integrating Google Gemini 2.0 API; building local deterministic regex failover engine; developing Cheerio directory crawler.	Weeks 5–7
Phase 4	Escrow Booking & Emergency Hub	Connecting Razorpay Orders API; implementing HMAC SHA-256 signature verification; deploying Emergency SOS and arrest rights module.	Weeks 8–9
Phase 5	Benchmarking & Documentation	Executing triage accuracy evaluations across 100 legal test cases; compiling final IEEE SRS report; project defense.	Weeks 10–12

Milestone Review Criteria & Risk Mitigation Plan

• **Milestone 1 (Week 4):** Client-side voice engine successfully captures spoken Hindi and English with live token streaming and under 200ms rendering latency.

• **Milestone 2 (Week 7):** Dual-engine triage pipeline achieves over 90% domain categorization precision with zero 500 errors during simulated cloud API dropouts.

• **Milestone 3 (Week 9):** Razorpay payment gateway successfully validates genuine signatures and rejects 100% of tampered transaction tokens; emergency SOS hub functions reliably.

• **Risk Mitigation Strategy:** If upstream LLM endpoints experience prolonged downtime or quota exhaustion, Vakil Setu automatically engages the local regex pattern-matching engine, guaranteeing uninterrupted citizen advisory without service degradation.

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